Tips for Teachers: Read to Self Time

Reading to Self *in English* is an important piece in creating intrinsic motivation for students. If they are to be self-motivated in learning English, it's important for them to choose their own books. Here are some tips (sourced from *The ELL Teacher's Toolbox* by Larry Terrazzo) to help with your English Learners.

Newcomer/Beginner

Finding Books

Below are some sources of free books. These books focus on building phonics skills and vocabulary. They require no sign-up and should work on their Chromebooks. I would post these on Clever.

Word-Building (Phonemic Awareness)

- Starfall
  - An oldie but a goodie. Since Starfall is based around word-building, it should be both developmentally appropriate and low-level. Start with the level closest to your grade, and work your way down if you see that the student is not understanding.

Vocabulary (Authentic Practice– Low Level)

- Storyplace Library
  - Students can choose certain themes to read a book. This is a site that has lots of other options on the sides, so make sure you discuss what is fair game. Specifically, reading only (not playing activities, though the activities would be good for other down time).
- Epic! Books
  - This is one most teachers are comfortable with. There are filters in order to help you search for what you desire.
- Library Resource Website
  - The "Books and Research" section of this website has many resources for books. Specifically, MackinVia has search filters on the sides to help you level books (also a good resource for parents as it has bilingual and Spanish books).
- ABRACADABRA
  - Students will really like the way this website is laid out. Make sure they are on the "Reading" section (though they could use the "Activity" section for independent time).

Following Up

Having conversations about reading is a great way to strengthen comprehension and communication skills. This could take the form of writing or talking with someone. Below is an example of how you might host reading conversations in your classroom.

Give students time to read, and then time to reflect through writing. Create a list of questions that students can return to each time. The questions should be simple but they should be in English. Giving students questions in English in small doses allows them to problem solve and use coping strategies to decode the meaning of a task. In order to hold accountability, you can make them choose a question each week and cross it off the list until every one is done. Then, print the list and make them do it over again until they've mastered comprehension of the questions. *Students can respond in their native language or in English, but the questions and books should be in English.* Some ideas for your question list are (you can differentiate these as you see fit for your grade):

- What is one new word you saw in this book and what does it mean? Can you use it in a sentence?
- What was your favorite part of this book? Why?
- Who, if anyone, would you recommend this book to?
- Draw a picture that represents what you read and write a sentence about your picture.
- Did you like the book? Why or why not?
- Pick one sentence from the book that explains the story well. Write it on your paper. Why did you pick it?

Support/Independent

<u>Finding Books</u>

For these students, it would be best to use whatever means you use for your non-ELL students. Encourage students with high reading levels in English to choose Spanish books in order to build transfer between the two languages. Not only will this in turn build bridges in their English language, but it will allow them to practice bilingualism, which is a huge asset in their future!

It's important that students understand the importance of choosing appropriate books. Host conversations with your students about what an appropriate book looks like. If a student picks a book that is too challenging but is motivated to read, try not to correct their decision. It is appropriate to get involved when a child is not challenging themselves enough or challenges themselves to the point of frustration.

<u>Following Up</u>

For higher-level ELL students, a list of questions to choose from would be helpful, but it doesn't necessarily need to be the same question every time. Below are some examples of fun questions students can answer for their reading.

- **Plot Twist:** Choose a part of the book you have read and make a change to the story. Why did you decide to make that change?
- **Therapist:** Give advice to one of the book characters. What would you tell him or her to do, and why?
- **Dear Diary:** Pick a character from your book and write a diary entry as that character.
- **Pokemon Card:** Pretend your character is on a Pokemon card. On one side of your paper, draw a picture of the character. On the other side, write important facts or traits.
- **What If?:** Write a "what if" question related to your book and answer your own question.